

1 • The source and the microphones

SoundVisualizer • chamber report, 2026-10-05 • what the room is measured with, and how far the numbers can be trusted



The chamber, photographed 5 Oct (after the measurements in this report, so the absorber layout may differ from the 25 Sep state): the arc ring laid flat around the propeller rig at the hub, the speaker tripod on the left, batting on the floor and ceiling, wedges and lined pillars on the walls.



The source: the printed 1 l sphere with its 8 cm driver, mounted at the hub. Every position map in this report comes from it. It is axisymmetric below 3 kHz; an $m = 1$ rocking mode at 4.4 kHz (11.0 dB) is why 3–5 kHz is excluded.

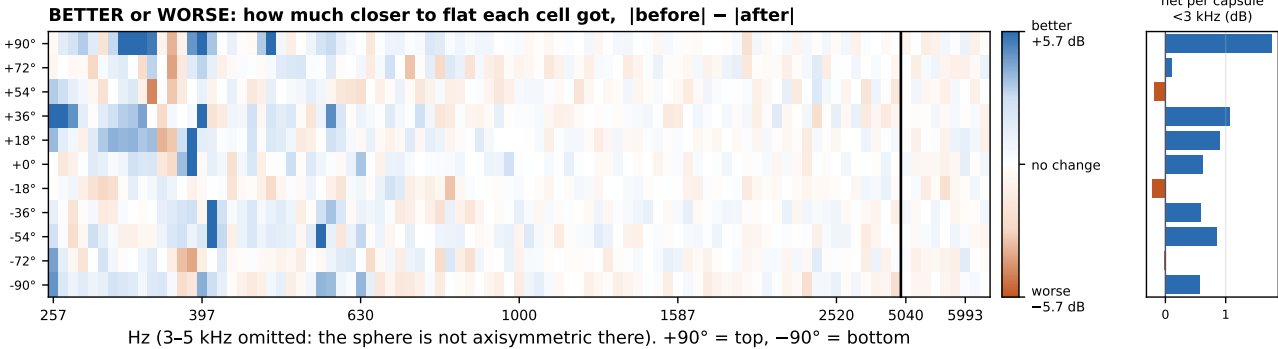
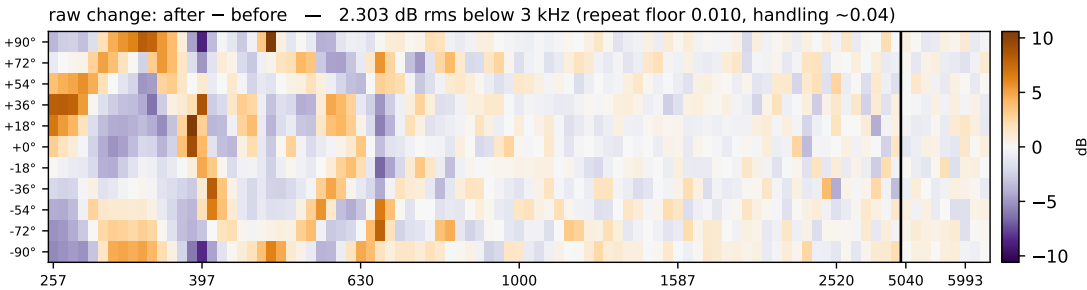
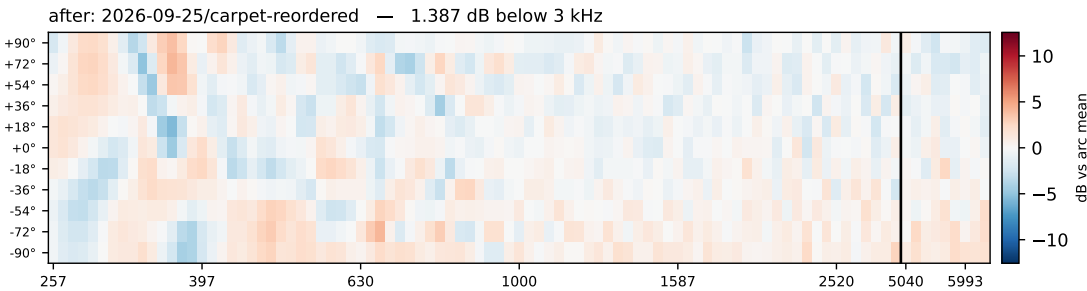
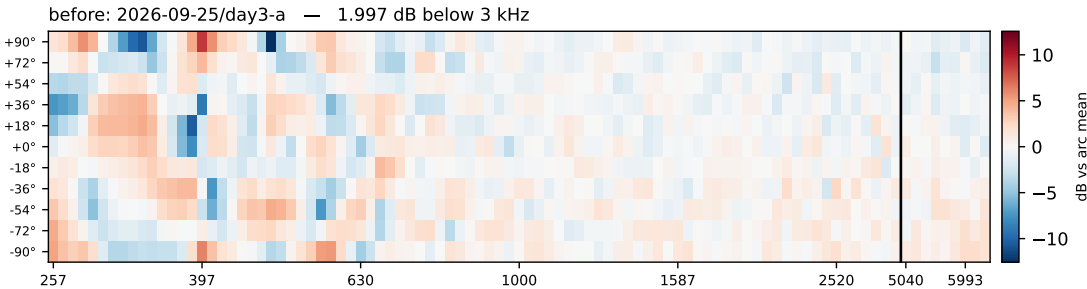
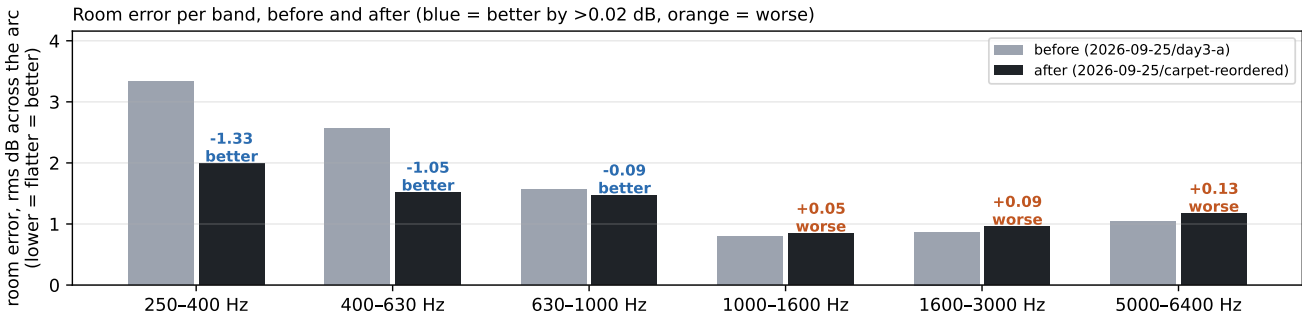
What we did with the microphones

- **Eleven UMIK-2 capsules on a 1.68 m ring**, all recording at once. The room is read as each capsule's level relative to the arc mean (room error), on a 95-tone grid, 257 Hz–6.35 kHz.
- **Substitution calibration, 16 Sep**: every capsule measured against every other at one seat (55 pairs, repeatability 0.08 dB sd). **Seven of the eleven factory files were wrong by 0.6–3.6 dB**, clustered by serial prefix. The corrections went into each capsule's calibration curve; the spread across the eleven fell from **4.01 dB to 0.02 dB**. The datum is the four capsules whose files agree with measurement. Still open: the absolute level, which needs a 94 dB calibrator.
- **Effect on the propeller data**: the 30 Sep prop-plane polar's roughness fell from 3.3 to 1.0 dB (–70 %) with the corrections applied to identical captures.
- **Is it the rig or the room? (17 Sep)** Flipping the arc and then standing it vertical showed that about 0.2 dB of the position map is arc hardware; the rest is the room.
- **Is it the source?** Rolling the driver inside a sphere that never moved changed the map by 0.20 dB rms below 3 kHz (86 tones), and by up to 11 dB at 3–5 kHz. Below 3 kHz the sphere is a valid source; the band above is masked.
- **Repeatability**: the same state measured twice gives 0.006–0.015 dB; handling an item in and out about 0.04 dB. That is the floor under every treatment comparison that follows.

Numbers from the project notes (CLAUDE.md, calibrator sessions 2026-09-16 and 2026-09-17), which govern where this page and they differ.

2 · Waterfall, day 3 start (worst) vs final · source moved in between: room error below 3 kHz 1.997 → 1.387 dB (-0.610, better)

2026-09-25/day3-a → 2026-09-25/carpet-reordered · below 3 kHz, 492 of 946 cells moved >0.05 dB toward flat and 415 away from it · 95 tones · 11 calibrated capsules



Hz (3-5 kHz omitted: the sphere is not axisymmetric there). +90° = top, -90° = bottom

2 · Day 3 evaluation by the chamber-qualification method

SoundVisualizer · 2026-10-01 · 11 calibrated capsules on a 0.84 m arc · 95 tones, 257 Hz–6.35 kHz · chapter 2, previous page: waterfall, 25 Sep, day3-a (13:17, worst of the day) → carpet-reordered (19:15, final)

The method

Chambers are qualified one one-third-octave band at a time against the free-field ideal; the cut-off is the lowest band above which everything passes, noise and pure tones separately. Limits: ±1.5 dB to 630 Hz, ±1.0 dB from 800 Hz (Cunefare et al. 2003, J. Acoust. Soc. Am. 113(2), p. 882, page 3). **Our adaptation:** eleven fixed positions around an axisymmetric source, so the reference is the arc mean; **band level** = each capsule's mean over the 8–9 tones in the band, worst capsule against the limit; **pure tones** = share of tone × capsule cells inside. Within ±0.03 dB of a limit is marginal (the largest difference between two same-day runs of one unchanged state, 5 pairs).

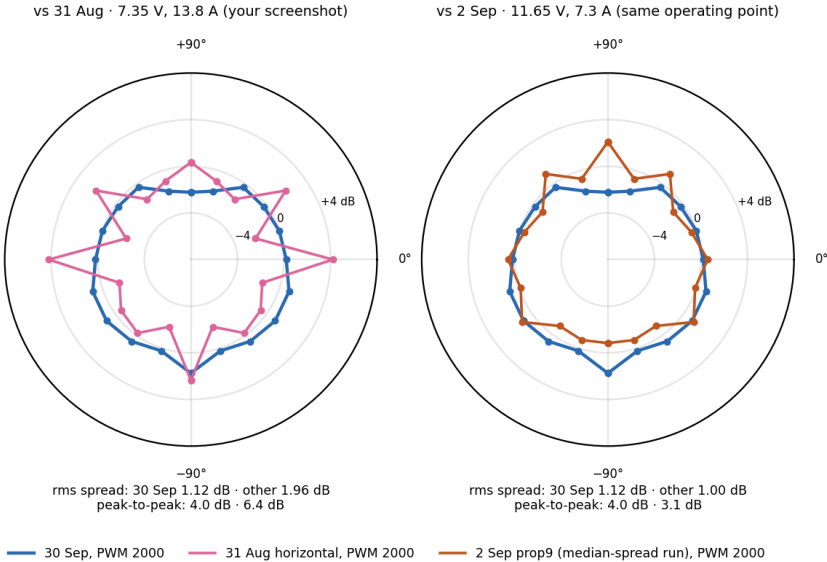
BAND	LIMIT	TONES	DAY 3 START	TONES IN LIMIT	FINAL	TONES IN LIMIT
250 Hz	±1.5	3	6.81	36 %	1.88	52 %
315 Hz	±1.5	8	3.46	28 %	0.89	56 %
400 Hz	±1.5	8	3.46	41 %	1.41	59 %
500 Hz	±1.5	8	1.93	41 %	1.99	59 %
630 Hz	±1.5	8	0.93	43 %	1.49	61 %
800 Hz	±1	8	0.87	60 %	1.12	55 %
1000 Hz	±1	9	1.08	71 %	0.57	73 %
1250 Hz	±1	8	0.54	83 %	1.02	73 %
1600 Hz	±1	8	0.69	75 %	1.15	76 %
2000 Hz	±1	8	0.66	84 %	0.77	82 %
2500 Hz	±1	8	0.82	64 %	0.75	65 %

MEASURE	DAY 3 START	FINAL
Room error below 3 kHz (dB)	1.997	1.387
Band-level qualified from	1250 Hz	2000 Hz
Bands clearly over the limit (of 11)	5: 250, 315, 400, 500, 1000 Hz	4: 250, 500, 800, 1600 Hz
Bands marginal	0: – Hz	2: 630, 1250 Hz
Pure-tone cells inside the limit	58 %	65 %

Blue = inside, yellow = marginal, orange = over. The cut-off is set by the highest failing band, so read it with the lists. **Caveat:** the source was moved between these runs (20 cm closer at 13:44, into the ring plane at 14:03): the map changed by 2.30 dB rms, against 0.14 for a re-arranged carpet and 0.80 for a 5 cm move, so the gain is treatments and source positions together. The one pair with an unmoved source is 24 Sep, empty floor 2.054 → carpet 1.317 (three arrangements 1.317 / 1.318 / 1.324).

3 · Polars: is the prop-plane polar rounder than before?

Tone-notched broadband 315 Hz-1 kHz, relative to each curve's own mean, zoomed to ±8 dB (on the full 0–80 dB SPL scale all three are near-round)



TONE-NOTCHED BROADBAND, 315 HZ-8 KHZ, CELLS WITHIN ±1.3 DB OF THE POLAR MEAN	RUNS	PWM 2000: MEDIAN (RANGE)	WORST CELL	PWM 1900: MEDIAN (RANGE)
30 Sep, today	1	66 %	3.1 dB	72 %
2 Sep, same operating point (11.65 V, 7.3 A, −4.0 N)	10	71 % (65–79)	3.4 dB	76 % (65–84)
31 Aug (7.35 V, 13.8 A, +6 N: other operating point)	5	65 % (38–68)	7.5 dB	62 % (38–66)

- Rounder than 31 Aug where it counts:** worst capsule 3.1 dB off the mean instead of 7.5 dB; the 31 Aug runs go down to 38 % of cells in tolerance. That run is the one in the screenshot, whose total level (tones included) is equally spread, 1.39 vs 1.41 dB; the gain is in the broadband.
- Not rounder than 2 Sep** (same voltage, current, thrust): 66 % against a median of 71 % (65–79), inside the scatter of the 2 Sep runs.
- Prop-plane measurement:** ends of the arc read louder than the centre at 2 and 4 kHz by +2.3 and +2.2 dB today, and by +1.5 and +4.3 dB (median) in the flat-arc runs where the true difference is zero: position-fixed error, not directivity.

4 · Semi-anechoic room solutions that apply to this chamber

What fails (accepted configuration, evaluated on its own): clearly over the ISO limit at 250, 500, 800, 1600 Hz, marginal at 630, 1250 Hz; the blade tone sits at 215–258 Hz and its third harmonic at 713 Hz. Nearest reflectors measured: extra path 0.68 m at –72° and 1.49 m at +36°/+54°, i.e. 1.98 and 4.34 ms. Source: chamber-fighting-guide.pdf §03, 29 facilities.

SOLUTION	WHAT THE PAPERS GIVE	APPLIES TO US?	WHAT WE ALREADY KNOW
1. Move the geometry (source, arc, reflector)	Sets the ceiling for everything else. Reaching 500 Hz needs every reflector ≥ 0.69 m of extra path, 250 Hz needs 1.37 m (gate ≥ 5 ms, Matelján, ARTA note 4).	Yes, first, free. The 0.68 m surface is just short for 500 Hz.	Source position was the largest lever in our trials: moving the speaker about 20 cm closer took the room error from 1.96 to 1.31 dB within one afternoon (25 Sep).
2. Measured room correction per position and tone	Source measured once in a real chamber and again in the room, band by band: "the uncertainty in measurements is minimal (below 0.55 dB for frequencies above 200 Hz)" (du Plessis et al. 2022, p. 29).	Yes, the strongest. Valid for a fixed source and fixed microphones — our arc — not for a flying drone.	Needs a reference run in a chamber (the university's 300 m ³). Void if a capsule is re-seated: 1 cm moves the response ± 6 dB at high frequency (Bellmann & Klippel, p. 7). Must be checked against the prop at 200–250 Hz (Mehrgou 2012, p. 34).
3. Average over source speed	Tones are where a modal room hurts most; a pattern that changes over a 19 % frequency step averages out over a speed ladder. No published residual.	Yes, cheap. Hardware exists; 12–15 PWM steps.	Tone-pattern holes of 8 dB moved with a 19 % frequency step in the flat-arc runs; the polar shape of 30 Sep depends on speed outside 1.3–2 kHz.
4. Time gating	Lowest usable frequency ≈ 1 / gate length: "the time-bandwidth requirement is satisfied on frequencies above 177.9Hz" for a 5.6 ms gate (Matelján, p. 8).	Only above 500 Hz: our gate is 1.98 ms.	Good for naming the 0.68 m and 1.49 m reflectors; cannot reach the blade tone.
5. Absorb: foam, wedges	34 cm of depth per 250 Hz; cost about $\times 4$ per octave down (Orrego et al. 2018, p. 477). Removing the floor treatment costs ~ 3 dB broadband and up to 10 dB at the blade tone (Ma et al. 2022, p. 7).	Not at 250 Hz. Yes at 630–1000 Hz: about 10 cm on the named surface.	The floor under the arc and source mattered most (wedges off: 2.05 $\rightarrow$ carpet 1.32, same afternoon); the same material on the walls did nothing.
6. Subwavelength absorber	"99.2% absorptance at 239 Hz in experiment" in 100 mm (Long et al. 2020, Sci. Rep. 10:13823).	The one exception for the blade tone, but only if the 238 Hz error is the room, not the stand.	Decide with the reverse-rotation capture first.

Order for this chamber

- Record the room (hub height, dimensions, what stands within 1.5 m of the arc ends) and move the 0.68 m reflector or the arc away from it.
- One capture with the propeller turning the other way, everything else identical: separates stand-induced from room-induced asymmetry.
- Loudspeaker correction at the blade harmonics (215–258 Hz, 713 Hz) for the eleven positions, then compare with the propeller at the same positions.
- Speed ladder to average the tones, then treat only the surfaces the sweep names (about 10 cm of foam at 630–1000 Hz).

"TABLE I. Maximum allowable difference in anechoic rooms between measured and theoretical free-field levels per ISO 3745 and ANSI S12.35." Cunefare et al. 2003, J. Acoust. Soc. Am. 113(2), p. 882

Where the accepted configuration stands, and what the method cannot say

- Evaluated on its own (25 Sep): room error 1.387 dB, qualified from the 2000 Hz band, 65 % of tone cells inside the limit. Published small rotor chambers report cut-offs of 63–275 Hz (29 facilities; METU's semi-anechoic room, 160 Hz, Kayhan 2008 p. 63); ours is 7–32 times higher, by a test easier in one respect (the arc mean, not the ideal, is the reference) and harder in another (the worst of eleven capsules).
- Deviation from the arc mean is blind to an error shared by all eleven positions; the ISO traverse has not been run, so this ranks bands and does not certify. The anechoic table is used because the floor under the arc is absorbing.
- Open, unexplained: a two-state switch in the source chain.** The arc-wide balance of 5–6.4 kHz against 257–400 Hz sits on two levels and flips by the same amount between neighbouring runs: foam-2 $\rightarrow$ foam-out -4.3, ceiling-carpet $\rightarrow$ ceiling-carpet-day2 (next morning) +4.4, ceiling1-floor2 $\rightarrow$ felt-floor-only -4.1, chaotic-carpet-2 $\rightarrow$ -3 +4.3, in-plane-b $\rightarrow$ curtain +4.6 dB. Speaker device and amplitude were unchanged at the same-day flips. Not a source move (a 5 cm move changes the map by 0.80 dB; the 24 Sep flip by 0.12), not redistributed absorber (room-only changes that afternoon moved the mean level by at most 0.13 dB), not a gain or supply-voltage change (that would shift every frequency alike; 257–400 Hz does not move). It cancels in the arc-relative score. To check: cable near the sphere, connectors, amplifier and supply (300 Hz and 5 kHz on live_tone while handling each).
- The grid starts at 257 Hz, above the blade tone; 3–5 kHz is excluded (sphere), 5–6.4 kHz indicative.